

Though we might eat a bowl of oatmeal oblivious to the medicinal benefits, it will, nonetheless, increase stamina, help the nervous system to function correctly, provide a good supply of B vitamins, and maintain regular bowel function. A similar range of benefits is provided by many of the other gentler-acting herbs listed in the *Encyclopedia*.

Herbal Treatments

The strategies that herbal practitioners adopt to prevent illness or restore health in their patients are different in the many and varied herbal traditions across the planet, but the effects that herbal medicines have within the body to improve health do not vary. There are many thousands of medicinal plants in use throughout the world, with a tremendous range of actions and degrees of potency. Most have a specific action on particular body systems and are known to be suitable for treating certain types of ailments. See p. 13 for specific actions.

Digestion, Respiration, & Circulation

Improving the quality of the diet is often an essential starting point in sustaining or regaining good health. The saying “You are what you eat” is by and large true, though herbalists prefer to qualify it, saying “You are what you *absorb* from what you eat.” Herbal medicines not only provide nutrients, but when needed they also strengthen and support the action of the digestive system, speeding up the rate of processing food and improving the absorption of nutrients.

The body requires another kind of “nutrient” to function—oxygen. The lungs and respiratory system can be helped with herbs that relax the bronchial muscles and stimulate respiration.

Once taken in by the body, nutrients and medicines are carried to the body’s estimated one hundred trillion cells. The circulatory system has a remarkable ability to adapt to an endlessly shifting pattern of demand. At rest, the flow of blood is mainly toward the center of the body, while when active, the muscles in the limbs make huge demands. Herbal medicines work to encourage circulation in particular ways. Some, for example, encourage blood to flow to the surface of the body; others stimulate the heart to pump more efficiently; while others relax the muscles of the arteries, lowering blood pressure.

Clearing Toxicity & Soothing Skin

After circulation has carried nutrients to the cells, waste matter must be removed. All too often in our polluted world, high levels of toxicity in the body are an underlying cause of ill health, and herbalists use a wide range of cleansing herbs that improve the body’s ability to remove toxins. Perhaps the finest example of a detoxifying herb is burdock (*Arctium lappa*, p. 65), which is used extensively in both Western and Chinese medicine. Once herbs such as this reduce the toxic

“load,” the body is able to invest greater resources in repairing and strengthening damaged tissue and weakened organs.

The skin also plays an important role in good health. Antiseptic plants fight infection, while vulnerary (wound-healing) herbs such as comfrey (*Symphytum officinale*, p. 138) encourage blood clotting and help speed the healing of wounds.

Nervous, Endocrine, & Immune Systems

Good health depends on having a healthy, balanced nervous system. In order to ensure long-term good health of the nervous system, it is important to adapt well to life’s daily demands, to avoid excessive anxiety, worry, or depression, and to get sufficient rest and exercise.

The latest research shows that the nervous system does not work in isolation but is complemented by the endocrine system, which controls the release of a whole symphony of hormones, including the sex hormones, which control fertility and often affect vitality and mood. The nervous system is also intimately linked with the immune system, which controls the ability to resist infection and to recover from illness and injury.

This incredible complex of systems—part electrical, part chemical, part mechanical—must function harmoniously if good health is to be maintained. In health, the body has a seemingly infinite capacity, via its controlling systems, to adjust and change to external pressures. This ability to adapt to the external world while the body’s internal workings remain constant is known as *homeostasis*. Many herbs work with the immune, nervous, and endocrine systems to help the body adapt more effectively to stresses and strains of all kinds: physical, mental, emotional, and even spiritual. They are effective because they work in tune with the body’s processes.

Some herbs are *adaptogenic*, meaning that they have an ability to help people to adapt, either by supporting the nervous system and easing nervous and emotional tension, or by working directly with the body’s own physiological processes to maintain health. The prime example of an adaptogenic herb is ginseng (*Panax ginseng*, p. 118), which is an effective remedy at times of great mental or physical stress, but in certain cases can also be taken when a relaxing effect is required, for example to relieve headaches, or to ensure a good night’s sleep.

Complex Natural Medicines

As can be seen, an herb is not a “magic bullet” with a single action, but a complex natural medicine composed of many active constituents that work on different body systems. By combining scientific research into active constituents with clinical observation and traditional knowledge of the whole plant, we can develop a rounded picture of each herb’s range of medicinal uses.